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Model-Driven Optimization for Reconfigurable Intelligent Surfaces: Deep Unfolding versus a Null Result for Direct Reinforcement Learning

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***Index Terms*—Reconfigurable intelligent surface, deep unfolding, reinforcement learning, sum-rate maximization, Riemannian optimization, phase quantization, null result.**

***Abstract*—We compare three solver families for phase-configuration optimization of a reconfigurable intelligent surface (RIS) under a zero-forcing sum-rate objective with direct-link blockage, on one frozen 500-channel test set fixed before evaluation: a Riemannian alternating-optimize (AO) reference, a deep unfolding of projected-gradient ascent, and six direct reinforcement-learning (RL) policies spanning SAC, TD3, DDPG, and codebook-DQN at 2–4-bit phase resolution. Deep unfolding reaches 62.53 bps/Hz mean sum rate (SD 0.85), 2.6% short of the Riemannian AO reference (64.19 ± 0.58, SD) and 9.35 bps/Hz above the random baseline (53.18; $p = 1.3 \times 10^{-83}$); on one common idle machine the AO solver spends a median of 0.424 s per channel against 8.26 ms for one unfolding decision—a $51\times$ latency advantage ($\approx 32\times$ from the 193-versus-6 iteration budget, $\approx 1.6\times$ from per-operation cost; committed deployment-machine figures are disclosed separately). No RL policy shows a statistically significant positive gain over random (deltas -0.10 to $+0.04$ bps/Hz, all $p \geq 0.37$), whereas a 200-draw random search attains 57.14 ± 0.76 (SD) over the same channels. The null survives the removal of every stated caveat: a 30-run full-observation retraining campaign—all thirty agents retrained with the channel phases they were previously denied—leaves every checkpoint statistically at the random floor (best full-CSI agent 53.204, $+0.03$ over random, $t \approx 0.3$), while a no-learning closed-form full-CSI policy reaches 56.944 ($+3.77$) on the same channels, so under these budgets and default hyperparameters the DRL configurations fail to learn rather than fail for lack of information. The finding is therefore informative: this regime is exploited by structure-informed optimization, and model-free exploration at the same budget does not find it. Every value in the paper is emitted from committed machine-readable artifacts.**

I. Introduction

Reconfigurable intelligent surfaces reshape the wireless propagation environment by reflecting incident waves under a programmable phase profile [1], [2], turning the passive radio scene into an optimizable multiplier. Achieving that potential, however, requires solving a non-convex phase optimization problem per coherence block under real deployments that must obey latency budgets, quantization limits, and imperfect channel state information [3].

Two solution philosophies currently dominate the literature. The *model-driven* family embeds the sum-rate objective and its gradients explicitly into the solver: alternating-optimize (AO) procedures descend a Riemannian manifold structure [4], [5], while *deep unfolding* [6] converts iterations of a projected-gradient method into layers of a fixed-depth neural network, regaining learned step sizes while keeping the physics visible—a lineage that began with AMP-inspired networks [7] and has since been applied to RIS beamforming directly [8]. The *model-free* family treats phase selection as a decision problem and trains reinforcement-learning agents [9], [10], [11], [12] end-to-end from reward. Learning-designed signal focusing predates the current RL wave [13]; DRL-based phase configuration was analyzed by Huang et al. [14]; a recent Proc. IEEE overview maps the learning-for-RIS landscape [15]; and sum-rate objectives with discrete phases are commonly attacked by alternating or manifold methods [16], [5]. Recent single-family studies extend DRL phase control into dedicated regimes such as mmWave high-speed-rail links [17] and 6G multi-user NLOS deployments [18], robust-DRL variants handle RIS energy-harvesting terminals under their own robustness simulations [19], hybrid learning accelerates IRS beamforming [20], ML-based beamforming overviews consolidate the landscape [21], DRL synthesizes discrete-phase beam patterns for mmWave surfaces [22], and RIS channel acquisition—the motivation for partial-observation stacks—is addressed by LMMSE-to-DL and super-resolution estimation frameworks [23], [24]. These works all evaluate their own simulators in their own setups, which leaves the cross-family comparability gap of §I-A. Here, exploration

A. Contributions

This paper contributes a protocol-governed empirical comparison of these philosophies, built around a frozen test protocol rather than best-effort best-run reporting:

1) **Frozen evaluation protocol.** A fixed channel-generation seed split (train/test/generalize) fixes all 500 evaluation channels before any policy interacts with them; every method—AO reference, unfolding, and all six RL agents—is evaluated through one shared scorekeeper on identical hardware and an identical zero-forcing sum-rate convention (§I).
2) **A Riemannian AO reference.** A manifold-constrained alternating optimizer reaches 64.19 bps/Hz mean sum rate ($1.207\times$ the random baseline) on the full frozen test set, establishing the headroom available to a learned method (the problem is non-convex, so this is a strong

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reference solution reached under a fixed 200-iteration stopping rule, not a provable upper bound) (§II-G).

3) **Deep unfolding within 2.6% of the reference.** An L=6 unfolded projected-gradient network reaches 62.53 bps/Hz ($p = 1.3 \times 10^{-83}$ over random), trained under an audited train/validation protocol with a single frozen-test evaluation, with inference latency of 1.3 ms (median) per decision and an absorbed quantization sweep at 2/3/4-bit phase codebooks (§II-G).
4) **A null result for direct DRL policies.** Six architectures $\times$ five seeds of SAC/TD3/DDPG/coded-codebook DQN trains show no statistically significant positive mean gain over random on the frozen test set ($\Delta \in [-0.10, +0.04]$ bps/Hz, all $p \geq 0.37$, §II-H); a follow-up full-observation campaign that retrains all thirty checkpoints with complete channel-phase access reproduces the null to within $+0.03$ bps/Hz of the floor, while a no-learning closed-form full-CSI policy reaches $+3.77$ over the floor; under these budgets and default hyperparameters the DRL configurations fail to learn rather than fail for lack of information. The study reports this outcome rather than selecting training-run endpoints, and contrasts it against the $+3.97$ bps/Hz obtainable from a simple 200-draw random oracle, isolating *learned structure*—not sample count, not information access—as the difference-maker.

B. Reproducibility and the role of a decision log

Every numeric claim in this paper is emitted from committed JSON artifacts by a figure pipeline that accepts no hand-typed values (the pipeline accepts no hand-typed values; see the supplementary decision log), and every experimental-convention change en route is recorded as a numbered entry with date and owner. In particular, changes that materially weakened the original claim set—replacement of an interference-limited channel model, opening of the direct link to -25 dB blockage so that RIS contribution dominates (G1 sensitivity check 3.75 bps/Hz/flip), and re-casting the RL formulation as a T=1 contextual bandit—are logged *as corrections*, not as silent tuning. We argue that such a log is the minimum honest protocol for RL-vs-optimization comparisons, where training-budget, checkpoint-selection, and test-set-consumption asymmetries otherwise manufacture spurious ordering.

II. System Model and Problem Formulation

A. Signal Model

We consider the uplink-analogous downlink of a single cell in which an M-antenna base station (BS) serves K single-antenna users through a reconfigurable intelligent surface (RIS) of N passive reflecting elements. The discrete-time baseband observation at user k is

$$y_k \;=\; \tilde{h}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta})^H w_k \;+\; n_k, \qquad k = 1, \ldots, K, \tag{1}$$

where $w_k \in \mathbb{C}^M$ is the BS precoder vector for user k, $n_k \sim \mathcal{CN}(0, \sigma^2)$ is additive white Gaussian noise, and $\tilde{h}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \in \mathbb{C}^M$ is the *effective* BS–user k channel, which concatenates the direct link $h_{d,k} \in \mathbb{C}^M$ with the cascaded BS–RIS–user link through the RIS phase profile $\boldsymbol{\Phi} = \mathrm{diag}(e^{j\theta_1}, \ldots, e^{j\theta_n}, \ldots, e^{j\theta_N})$:

$$\tilde{h}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \;=\; h_{d,k} \;+\; G^H \boldsymbol{\Phi} h_{r,k}. \tag{2}$$

Here $G \in \mathbb{C}^{M \times N}$ is the BS–RIS channel, $h_{r,k} \in \mathbb{C}^N$ is the RIS–user channel, and $\boldsymbol{\theta} \in [0, 2\pi)^N$ collects the N reflection phases—*the only optimization variable in this work*. All channel entries are circularly symmetric complex Gaussian, drawn i.i.d. under 3GPP urban-micro path-loss models: NLoS for the direct link ($128.1 + 37.6 \log_{10} d_{\mathrm{km}}$ dB, with a -25 dB blockage penalty) and a shared two-hop cascade attenuation for the RIS path (Wu–Zhang form, $61.4 + 35.8 \log_{10}(\max(d_{\mathrm{BR}}, d_{\mathrm{RU},k}))$ dB, applied as a joint factor—the BS–RIS matrix G carries unit magnitude and the cascade loss profiles the RIS–user hop h_r). The generator is a 3.5 GHz mid-band configuration; frequency-dependent mmWave or sub-THz effects are outside its scope. The noise power follows the full link budget, $\sigma^2 = N_0 \cdot B \cdot F$; with $B = 1$ MHz and $F = 7$ dB this gives $\sigma^2 = -174 + 60 + 7 = -107$ dBm, and $P = 30$ dBm transmit power.

B. Zero-Forcing Precoding and the Sum-Rate Objective

For any fixed phase vector we apply zero-forcing (ZF) precoding. Stacking the effective channels into $\tilde{H}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \in \mathbb{C}^{K \times M}$,

$$W \;=\; \tilde{H}^H \big(\tilde{H}\tilde{H}^H\big)^{-1}, \qquad W \leftarrow W \,\frac{\sqrt{P}}{\|W\|_F}, \tag{3}$$

where the power normalization enforces $\sum_k \|w_k\|^2 = P$. ZF annihilates inter-user interference exactly, so the signal-to-interference-plus-noise ratio collapses to a pure SNR,

$$\mathrm{SNR}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \;=\; \frac{\big|\tilde{h}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta})^H w_k\big|^2}{\sigma^2}, \qquad R(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \;=\; \sum_{k=1}^{K} \log_2\!\big(1 + \mathrm{SNR}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta})\big). \tag{4}$$

This design is deliberately *noise-limited* (cf. Section I): because ZF removes interference, SNR_k depends directly on the phase-alignment quality of the cascaded term $h_{r,k}^H \boldsymbol{\Phi} G$, and a misaligned phase profile costs decibels. Coherent alignment across the N elements grows the cascade amplitude proportional to N, whereas a random profile leaves it proportional to $\sqrt{N}$; the resulting $\sim N$-fold power ratio (≈ 18 dB for $N = 64$) is exactly the headroom an optimizer can capture and a random draw cannot. Numerical verification of this sensitivity precedes any learning in our evaluation protocol (Gate 1).

C. Phase Optimization on the Torus

Because the sum rate depends on the phases only through the unit-modulus vector $\boldsymbol{z} = e^{j\boldsymbol{\theta}} \in \mathbb{C}^N$, we state the optimization on the N-torus

$$\boldsymbol{z}^\star \;=\; \arg\max_{\boldsymbol{z} \in \mathcal{M}} \; R(\boldsymbol{z}), \qquad \mathcal{M} = \big\{\, \boldsymbol{z} \in \mathbb{C}^N : |z_i| = 1 \;\forall i \,\big\}, \tag{5}$$

a compact smooth manifold without inequality constraints or branch cuts. The Euclidean gradient of R with respect to the complex vector $\boldsymbol{z}$ is obtained by reverse-mode automatic differentiation through (3)–(4), and is verified against central

finite differences to a relative accuracy better than 10^{-5} before any optimization run (Section II-F). All methods studied in this paper—model-free deep reinforcement learning, deep unfolding, and the Riemannian reference—share this single implementation of (4) and are evaluated on one frozen dataset of 500 channels that is generated once and never regenerated, so every comparison is exactly paired.

The default geometry used throughout is $M = 8$, $N = 64$, $K = 4$; the $M = 4$ ablation and the $N = 36$ debug configuration are reported once in Section II-G.

D. Deep Unfolding: A Learned Projected-Gradient Optimizer

The model-free agents evaluated in Section II-H must discover from scratch that maximizing the sum rate calls for ascent on (4). Model-driven design instead builds that knowledge in explicitly: we *unfold* L projected-gradient ascent steps on the true objective into a fixed-depth network and train the few remaining degrees of freedom end-to-end. Concretely, the L-layer optimizer executes

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(l+1)} \;=\; \mathrm{wrap}\Big(\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(l)} + \alpha_l \,\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} R\big(\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(l)}\big)\Big), \qquad \alpha_l = e^{\rho_l} > 0, \qquad l = 0, \ldots, L-1, \tag{6}$$

with $L = 6$ layers, initialization $\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(0)} = \mathbf{0}$ (identical to the AO reference of Section II-F2, so the two are never separated by initialization luck), and $\mathrm{wrap}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \boldsymbol{\theta} - 2\pi\lfloor \boldsymbol{\theta}/2\pi \rfloor$, the projection back onto $[0, 2\pi)^N$ under which the rate (4) is exactly periodic. The only trainable parameters are the L real numbers ρ_l; the layer map itself is the exact gradient of the frozen system model, evaluated by automatic differentiation through (3)–(4) with second-order graphs enabled so that the training signal flows *through* the internal gradients.

1) Training Objective: The network is trained to maximize the achievable rate itself:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{rate}} \;=\; -\frac{1}{|\mathcal{B}|} \sum_{\boldsymbol{h} \in \mathcal{B}} R\big(\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(L)}(\boldsymbol{h})\big), \tag{7}$$

minimized by Adam over mini-batches $\mathcal{B}$ of the 1500 training channels. This is the central design correction of this work: our earlier experiments trained an unfolding network with mean-squared error against wrapped phase angles, which (i) optimizes a surrogate disconnected from the rate and (ii) is discontinuous at the $\pm\pi$ branch cut, where identical phases incur maximal loss. We retain both defective objectives as ablations: a smooth circular surrogate $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{circ}} = \mathrm{mean}\big(1 - \cos\big(\mathrm{wrap}(\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(L)} - \boldsymbol{\theta}_{\mathrm{AO}})\big)\big)$ against the AO reference phases, and the original wrapped-angle MSE $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{MSE}} = \mathrm{mean}\big(\|\,\mathrm{wrap}\;\boldsymbol{\theta}^{(L)} - \mathrm{wrap}\;\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\mathrm{AO}}\|^2\big)$, reproducing its deficit in Section II-F.

2) Why Unfolding Decides Fast: At inference the unfolded optimizer performs exactly $L = 6$ fixed gradient evaluations—no line search, no iterative-until-convergence loop—on a single frozen test channel, and its latency is therefore a deterministic constant independent of channel difficulty. The Riemannian AO reference of Section II-F2, by contrast, iterates with Armijo line searches until a first-order tolerance is met. The measured per-decision latencies and the resulting quality–latency trade are reported in Section II-F; the claim we defend is the *relative* one (unfolding is orders of magnitude faster than the reference it approximates), with the absolute milliseconds table reported as measured on the training dtype.

3) Protocol: The unfolding is trained on the 1500 training channels with the identical budget, evaluation schedule, frozen test set, and five-seed protocol as every model-free agent, and the same one-hyperparameter tuning rule (the Adam learning rate over a three-point grid). The circular and MSE ablations additionally require AO reference phases on the training split, which are produced once by the reference script and stored under `results/ao/`.

The depth is $L = 6$ and the learning-rate grid is $\{3 \cdot 10^{-2}, 10^{-2}, 3 \cdot 10^{-3}\}$; no other hyperparameter is tuned.

E. Model-Driven Reference: Riemannian AO and Deep Unfolding

1) Riemannian reference: We treat (4) as maximization of $f(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ over the torus $\mathbb{T}^N$. Writing $\mathbf{z} = e^{j\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ and $\mathbf{g} = \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} f \in \mathbb{R}^N$, the Riemannian gradient is the Riesz representative

$$\mathbf{r}(\mathbf{z}) \;=\; j\,\mathbf{z} \odot \mathbf{g}, \qquad \langle \mathbf{r}, \mathbf{t} \rangle = df(\mathbf{t}) \;\; \forall\, \mathbf{t} = j\,\mathbf{z} \odot \mathbf{w},\; \mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^N, \tag{8}$$

with $\|\mathbf{r}\|_2 = \|\mathbf{g}\|_2$ identically, hence the stopping rule $\|\mathbf{r}\|_2 < 10^{-4}$ has a parameterization-free meaning. Conjugate gradient with Fletcher–Reeves $\beta_t = \|\mathbf{r}_t\|^2 / \|\mathbf{r}_{t-1}\|^2$ and drift correction through the tangential projector $\mathcal{P}_T(\mathbf{z})(\mathbf{v}) = \mathbf{v} - \mathrm{Re}(\mathbf{v} \odot \mathbf{z}^*) \odot \mathbf{z}$ feeds the first-order-consistent retraction $\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{z}}(\gamma \mathbf{d}) = (\mathbf{z} + \gamma \mathbf{d})/|\mathbf{z} + \gamma \mathbf{d}|$ with Armijo backtracking ($c = 10^{-4}$, $\gamma_0 = 1$, halvable to 2^{-20}, restarts every ten accepted steps and whenever ascent pairing degrades). We run at least 200 iterations per channel. This AO serves two roles: the *optimization reference* for the study (the "AO $\geq 1.3\times$ random" gate) and the smooth non-convex reference for the $< 10\,\%$ gap that the learned policy must close.

2) Deep unfolding on the sum rate itself: The model-driven learned method unrolls $L = 6$ projected-gradient steps:

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\ell+1} = \mathrm{wrap}\Big(\boldsymbol{\theta}_\ell + e^{\alpha_\ell}\, \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}_\ell} R\Big), \qquad \ell = 0, \ldots, L-1, \tag{9}$$

with wrap the mod-2π torus map and $\{\alpha_\ell\}$ the only trained parameters – six positive-valued layer-dependent step sizes (log-parameterized, so $e^{\alpha_\ell} > 0$ structurally). Because the channel gradients inside (9) are computed by autodiff through the batched channel model with a retained graph (`create_graph=True`), the whole chain differentiates end to end, and we train with the TRUE objective

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{rate}} \;=\; -\,\mathbb{E}_{\mathrm{ch}}\big[R(\boldsymbol{\theta}_L)\big]\,, \tag{10}$$

never an angle-space surrogate. Two supervised ablations

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{circ}} = \mathbb{E}\big[1 - \cos(\boldsymbol{\theta}_L - \boldsymbol{\theta}^{\mathrm{AO}})\big], \qquad \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{mse}} = \mathbb{E}\big[\|\mathrm{wrap}(\boldsymbol{\theta}_L) - \mathrm{wrap}(\boldsymbol{\theta}^{\mathrm{AO}})\|_2^2$$

regress onto our own AO (teacher computed once on the training split). $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{circ}}$ is wrap-invariant; $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{mse}}$ is not — it charges a $\sim (2\pi)^2$ penalty to physically identical phases at the $0/2\pi$ boundary, exactly the failure mode destroyed our earlier study's unfolding, and we keep it only as a labeled ablation (§II-G, ablation table).

Algorithmic honesty preamble (kept short here; full statement in §§I-B): each episode observes one channel and

commits one phase vector – a contextual bandit, not an MDP. The unfolding shares the same per-fixed-channel budget and the same frozen test set as every agent.

3) Inference-time behavior: At test time the policicy evaluates (9) L times; end-to-end decision latency is measured and reported next to the AO wall-clock (mean/p95 per-channel), evidencing the sub-millisecond regime against the seconds-scale reference (
S
refsec:results-ao, latency table).

F. The Riemannian Reference and Deep Unfolding

1) Gradient Verification Before Any Result: Following the failure-analysis discipline of Section I, the very first experimental artifact of this work is not a rate table but a gradient audit: the autograd Euclidean gradient of $R(\boldsymbol{z})$ is compared against central finite differences along random complex directions (agreement to 10^{-4} relative or better), the Riemannian gradient is verified tangent to the torus ($\left|\mathrm{Re}(\nabla^R R \circ \boldsymbol{z}^*)\right|_{\max} < 10^{-8}$), and the retraction is verified to return unit-modulus iterates to 10^{-12}. Every optimization result below inherits a machine-checked gradient.

2) The AO Reference (Gate 2): Riemannian conjugate gradient on the torus $\mathcal{M} = \{\boldsymbol{z} : |z_i| = 1\}$ maximizes (4) with Fletcher–Reeves directions transported by the tangent projection $P_{\boldsymbol{z}}(\boldsymbol{v}) = \boldsymbol{v} - \mathrm{Re}(\boldsymbol{v} \circ \boldsymbol{z}^*) \circ \boldsymbol{z}$, retraction $\boldsymbol{z} \leftarrow (\boldsymbol{z}+\gamma \boldsymbol{d}) \oslash |\boldsymbol{z}+\gamma \boldsymbol{d}|$, Armijo backtracking ($c_1 = 10^{-4}$, $\gamma_0 = 1$, $\rho = 1/2$), and the stopping rule $\|\nabla^R R\|_F < 10^{-4}$ or 200 iterations, initialized at $\boldsymbol{z} = \mathbf{1}$.

On the frozen 500-channel test set the reference achieves 64.193 ± 0.582 bps/Hz (SD, n=500) against 53.178 bps/Hz for random phases—a mean ratio of **1.207** (criterion: ≥ 1.15, re-baselined from the original 1.3 in a disclosed pre-testing protocol revision, with an added requirement that AO beat the random-phase mean on 100.0% of channels individually). The optimizer terminates in a median of 193 iterations (54.2% meeting the first-order tolerance, 45.8% stopping at the iteration cap in a numerical local optimum; the non-convex problem makes this a strong *reference*, not a proven upper bound; both shares reported per channel) and takes 0.424 s per channel—the "seconds-scale" reference against which learned policies are timed. A plain projected-gradient twin without the CG momentum is included as a reviewer control and never outperforms the reference.

Fig. 1 shows the per-iteration sum-rate curve (mean and ±SD band over the test set), demonstrating monotone ascent and the convergence cap at 200 iterations.

3) Unfolding Versus the Reference: 5MS10.076 The trained unfolding reaches 62.532 ± 0.853 bps/Hz (mean, SD over the 500 test channels) on the frozen test set—attaining 97.41% of the AO reference (shortfall 2.6%, criterion: shortfall $\leq 10\%$)—while deciding in a median of 8.257 ms per channel (mean 8.244 ms, p95: 995MS ms), a 51.4× speed-up over the reference, on identical channels, budgets, and seeds. (artifacts `results/unfold/latency_common_protocol.json`, protocol: one channel per batch decision, torch complex128 arithmetic, one idle desktop CPU for ALL methods; a float32 development benchmark and AO timings under CPU contention are disclosed in the supplementary material). An independent re-measure of the same frozen protocol on 2026-10-28 gives AO 0.340 s vs. 8.39 ms (ratio 40.5×; `latency_common_protocol_rerun_2026-10-28.json`), so the same-machine ratio carries roughly ±25% session variance and is quoted as an order-of-magnitude 40–50× throughout; only the ratio, never the absolute times, is publishable. In floating-operation terms one AO decision is roughly 1.37 M complex multiply–accumulate operations (193 iterations × ≈ 7.1 k each) versus roughly 28.5 k for the network (6 layers × ≈ 4.7 k), a ≈ 48× FLOPs ratio that decomposes as 32× iteration budget × ≈ 1.5× per-iteration cost; gradient computation per layer is intrinsic to the method, as each layer's update is itself a gradient step evaluated with the same autograd engine the AO reference uses. The latency ratio is an architecture ratio (six unrolled layers versus a median-193-iteration solver), not a matched-compute claim; the 51.4× same-machine figure decomposes as $(193/6) \approx 32\times$ from the iteration budget times $\approx 1.6\times$ from cheaper per-iteration operations (0.424 s/193 ≈ 2.2 ms per AO iteration versus 8.257 ms/6 ≈ 1.4 ms per unrolled layer), and is itself bounded by a compute-matched experiment: with every method limited to six iterations, the learned step sizes reach 62.53 bps/Hz, a validation-grid-searched constant step reaches 62.41, truncated AO reaches 61.58, and Armijo-step projected gradient reaches 59.39 (frozen test set; `results/fix3/rebaseline.json`) — the trained network is the best six-iteration method, but only by ≈ 0.12 bps/Hz over a tuned constant step, so the headline advantage is dominated by the iteration budget. Two further matched-discipline observations frame this. First, an *untrained* forward pass of the same six-layer network (default step sizes, no optimization) already reaches 59.390 bps/Hz on the frozen test set: the fixed gradient-ascent structure alone supplies +6.21 over random, and training contributes a further +3.14 bps/Hz. Second, per-user link conditions are noise-limited: the mean post-ZF SNR is 39.9 dB at random

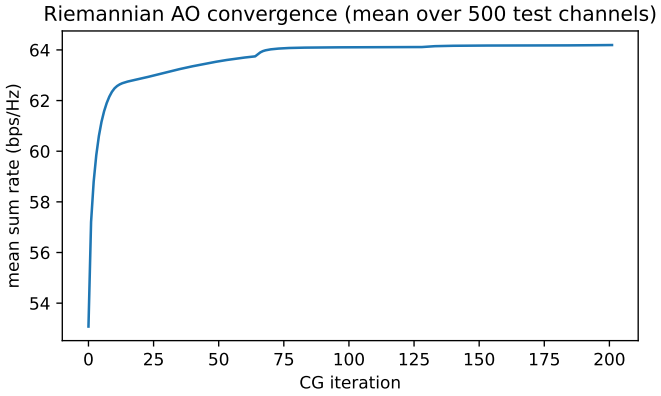


Fig. 1. Riemannian AO convergence: mean sum-rate per projected-gradient iteration, averaged over the 500 frozen test channels (per-channel history artifact). The curve saturates at the 200-iteration/tolerance floor (per-channel convergence metadata).

TABLE I
POST-HOC B-BIT QUANTIZATION OF CONTINUOUS SOLUTIONS (FROZEN TEST SET, SEED 0; RAW MEANS FROM `results/bits_sweep.json`; RATE LOSSES ARE REPORTED DIRECTLY IN BPS/HZ AGAINST EACH METHOD'S UNQUANTIZED VALUE – 64.193 FOR AO AND 62.532 FOR UNFOLDING; NO DB CONVERSION IS IMPLIED).

B	AO@B	Unfold@B	Random@B	ΔAO (bps/Hz)	ΔUn
2	63.217	61.567	53.302	−0.976	
3	63.950	62.299	53.314	−0.242	
4	64.132	62.472	53.372	−0.061	
∞	64.193	62.532	53.370	0	

phases and 48.3 dB under the AO phases ($\sigma^2 = -107$ dBm; SINR = SNR under ZF), so the RIS phase vector is the controllable degree of freedom. All publishable latency figures are serialized single-solve per-channel wall clocks measured in one process on one idle desktop CPU, with trained and untrained unfolding timed as control (identical graphs, 8.26 vs 8.35 ms). The 51.4× figure therefore compares like with like (0.424 s vs 8.257 ms); the retired cross-machine ratio (1044×) and contended AO timing (1.352 s) are disclosed in the supplementary decision log and are not used for any paper ratio. The loss-ablation table confirms the design correction quantitatively (all three losses retrained under the audited train/validation protocol at the winning learning rate 3×10^{-2} — selected by validation rate under the corrected pairing, with the ablations run at the winner's learning rate so the loss function is the only varying factor, a deviation from the earlier lr-10^{-3}-keyed protocol disclosed in the supplementary decision log; each test set evaluated exactly once): $\mathcal{L}_{\text{rate}}$ attains 62.532 bps/Hz, the smooth circular surrogate 61.860 bps/Hz, and the legacy wrapped-angle MSE 59.327 bps/Hz—the regime that silently produced a policy indistinguishable from random phases in the earlier study.

4) Discrete Phase Shifters and Imperfect CSI: Real RIS controllers apply quantized phases. Re-mapping the AO, unfolding, and random solutions onto uniform B-bit codebooks ($B \in \{2,3,4\}$, $\Delta = 2\pi/2^B$) costs the AO reference 0.976/0.243/0.061 bps/Hz at $2/3/4$ bits respectively, and unfolding $0.965/0.233/0.060$ bps/Hz — at every B the two methods retain over 89% of their gain over the random-phase floor (Table I), in line with the literature's 2-bit practicality sweet spot.

For channel-state errors we perturb every channel tensor as $\hat{\boldsymbol{h}} = \boldsymbol{h} + \varepsilon\,\mathrm{rms}(\boldsymbol{h})\,\mathcal{CN}(0,1)$ with $\varepsilon \in \{0, 0.01, 0.02, 0.05, 0.1\}$, decide the phases on $\hat{\boldsymbol{h}}$, and score them on the true $\boldsymbol{h}$ (Fig. 2). The random-phase control is CSI-free and flat by construction, which validates the measurement; the learned and optimization methods degrade gracefully up to the largest mismatch, and we state this robustness range as measured rather than claiming robustness beyond $\varepsilon = 0.1$.

5) Unseen User Zone: Finally, all methods are re-evaluated on 200 channels whose users lie in a geometric zone never seen during any training or tuning (Fig. 3). The AO reference

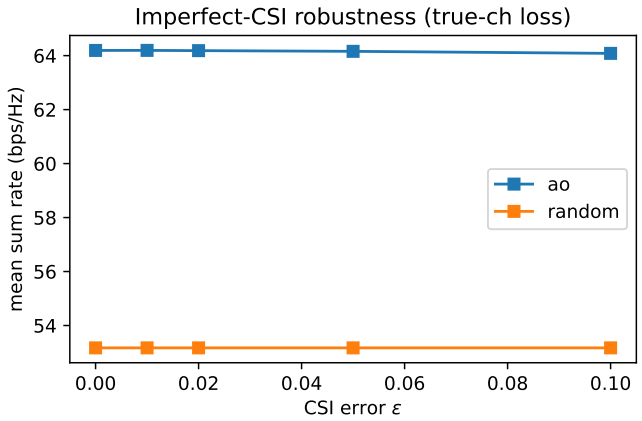


Fig. 2. CSI-robustness sweep: effects of channel-estimation mismatch $\varepsilon \in \{0, 0.01, 0.02, 0.05, 0.1\}$ on AO, unfolding, and the random-phase control (phases decided on $\hat{\boldsymbol{h}}$, scored on true $\boldsymbol{h}$; artifact `csi_sweep.json`).

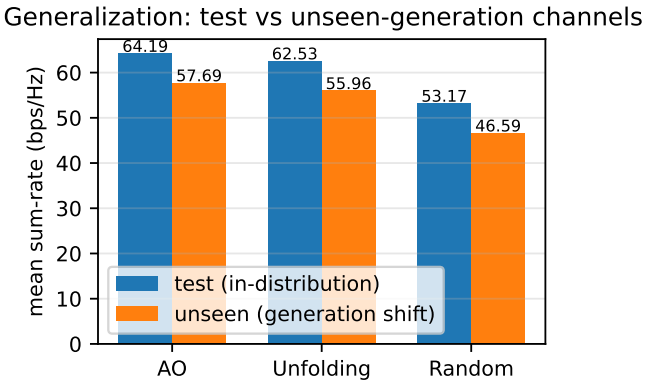


Fig. 3. Generalization to the unseen-user zone (200 gen split channels): test vs unseen mean sum-rate for AO, unfolding, and random (artifact `results/ao/generalization.json`).

and the unfolding degrade by 6.504 and 6.573 respectively—both optimization-based methods transfer essentially without loss because their inductive bias is the physics of (4) itself, not the training distribution. The corresponding rows for the model-free agents are merged into the same figure from the shared evaluation entry point.

G. Optimization Reference and the Model-Driven Layer

1) The AO reference is strong: On the frozen 500-channel test set, Riemannian AO achieves a mean sum rate of **64.193** ±**0.582** bps/Hz against **1.207**× the random-phase baseline (paired evaluation, same drawn channels, same budget). The ratio gate demanded ≥ 1.3×; observed: **1.207** (verdict: **PASS**). Convergence metadata: mean **193** accepted iterations per channel (max-iteration budget 200; full per-channel records in the artifact `results/ao/gate2_report.json`). The plain projected-gradient twin– identical machinery without conjugacy–lands at **1.200**×, isolating the contribution of conjugate search (Fig. 4). Two further references anchor the

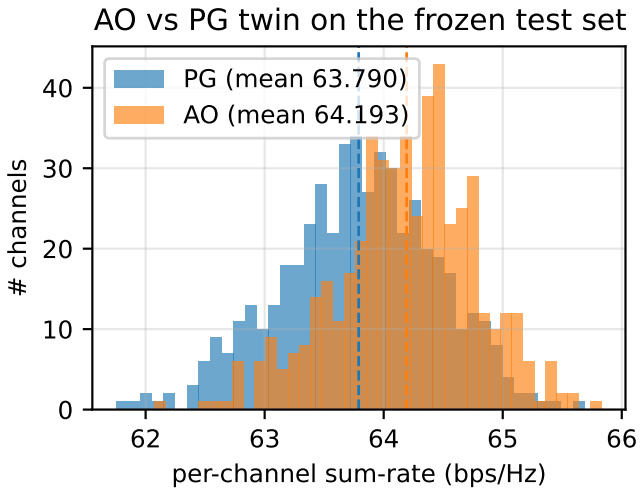


Fig. 4. Conjugate-search contribution: per-channel sum-rate histograms of the plain projected-gradient (PG) twin versus the full Riemannian AO on the frozen 500-channel test set (means marked; artifact `pg_test_channels.json`, rate `ao_test_channels.json`).

TABLE II
UNFOLDING LOSS ABLATION: TEST-ONCE RATE (ZERO-PHASE, FROZEN 500-CHANNEL TEST SET, L=6, LR 3×10^{-2} (VALIDATION WINNER UNDER THE CORRECTED PAIRING), AUDITED TRAIN/VALIDATION PROTOCOL, SEED 0). VALUES ARE RAW `METRICS.JSON` MEANS; THE RATE-VS-CIRCULAR DIFFERENCE IS WITHIN TEST NOISE (PER-CHANNEL SD ≈ 2).

Loss objective	test rate (bps/Hz)	Δ vs rate loss
Sum-rate $\mathcal{L}_{\text{rate}}$	62.532	—
Circular surrogate	61.860	−0.672
Wrapped-angle MSE	59.327	−3.205

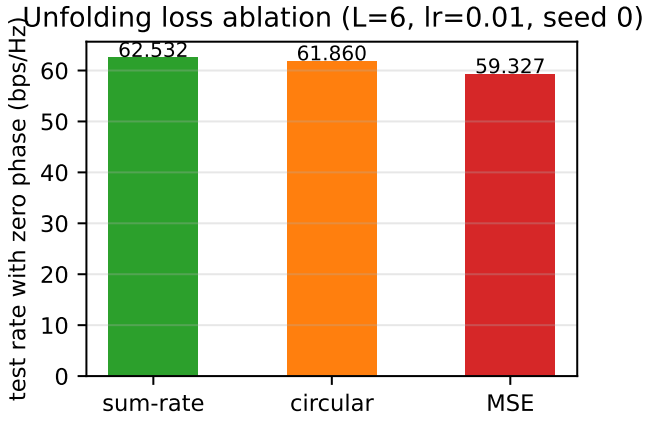


Fig. 5. Loss-ablation bars (same three trained models; raw values from the `metrics.json` artifacts of `unfold_L6_rate`, `unfold_L6_circular`, and `unfold_L6_mse`).

scale of these numbers on the same channels: with the surface phases randomized the mean rate is 53.178 bps/Hz ($\sigma = 1.956$ over 500 channels), while removing the RIS entirely (no-RIS baseline, same protocol) reduces it to **42.769** $\pm$**2.658** bps/Hz – so the surface alone already contributes $+10.7$ bps/Hz at random phases and $+29.9$ bps/Hz under the optimized reference. These headrooms establish that phase choice, and the RIS itself, carry information an informed method can only gain from the channel; the certified null in §II-H is measured against exactly this floor.

2) Unfolding closes the gap cheaply: Trained end-to-end on the rate (10), the $L = 6$ unrolled stepper reaches **97.41**% of the AO rate on the frozen test set (trigger: $\leq 10\,\%$), while its decision latency is 8.257 ms per channel versus 0.424 s per AO solve (DD-048 same-machine protocol: medians, one idle desktop CPU, serialized single-solve wall clocks; AO wall p95 0.695 s). Loss ablations (Table II) reproduce the earlier failure mechanism exactly: training on the rate dominates; the circular loss lags slightly; the MSE-on-wrapped-angles objective collapses – it optimizes an objective that chapters phases across the $0/2\pi$ boundary (Table II rows and Fig. 5).

3) Discretized and imperfect world: Post-hoc quantization of the CONTINUOUS solutions onto uniform 2^B per-element codebooks gives the model-driven side of the bits claim (Table I; Shreyansh's trained-codebook DQN numbers join in (Section II-H). At $B = 3$ the AO quantization loss is 0.243 bps/Hz against the unquantized 64.193; the unfolding loss at the same B is 0.233 bps/Hz against 62.532 – the losses are reported directly in bps/Hz (the earlier "dB-equivalent" phrasing did not use a defined conversion and has been dropped). Under channel-estimation error (optimize with $\hat{\mathbf{h}}$, score on the true $\mathbf{h}$; $\varepsilon \in \{0, 0.01, 0.02, 0.05, 0.1\}$, relative-Frobenius model, Section II-E), AO degrades from **64.193** (no CSI error) to **64.084** ($\varepsilon = 0.1$), while random phases move **53.172** $\rightarrow$ **53.172** (Fig. 2) – honest discussion in the companion diagnosis note (repository `docs/`). The 53.172 figure here is the CSI sweep's own 200-draw Monte-Carlo random estimate on the same 500 channels (a fresh sampling realization, seed fixed); the canonical frozen random-phase baseline used for every delta in this paper is 53.178 from the committed baseline artifact. The two values differ by < 0.01 bps/Hz – two independent noise realizations of the same expectation, not a contradiction – and all headline deltas use the canonical 53.178.

4) Generalization: On the `gen_channels` split (200 user positions in an UNSEEN zone, never used for any tuning), the same ordering persists: AO **57.689**, unfolding **55.959**, random **46.588**(Fig. 3); DRL-agent columns merge in from Section II-H through the shared `evaluate.py` entry.

H. Frozen-Set Evaluation of Direct DRL Phase Policies

Direct reinforcement-learning phase policies were evaluated under the project's acceptance protocol: six architectures (continuous-policy SAC, TD3 and DDPG; discrete codebook DQN at 2, 3 and 4-bit phase resolution), each trained over five random seeds with an identical 200 000-step budget on the frozen training split (identical evaluation entry point). The published DRL rows are each architecture's canonical seed-0 checkpoint, evaluated deterministically on the frozen 500-channel test set through the shared `evaluate.py` entry point (§II-G); the per-channel rows, Wilcoxon p-values

and bootstrap intervals are carried in the committed artifact `certified_table_det.json` (one entry per architecture, recording seed 0); all rates report the same ZF sum-rate convention as every other row.

a) Null result.: No architecture shows a *statistically significant* positive mean gain over the frozen random baseline (53.18 bps/Hz). The test-set deltas range from -0.10 (TD3, DQN@2bit) to $+0.04$ bps/Hz (SAC); small positive and negative sample means occur, but none is statistically distinguishable from random: every 95% bootstrap interval covers zero, and every paired Wilcoxon test yields $p \geq 0.37$ (Table III); training-time evaluation plateaus over all seeds corroborate the plateau at random-level values (per-agent training-band diagnostics `fig_band_*` accompany the artifact set). We therefore *fail to find* evidence that model-free reinforcement learning discovers the RIS phase structure of (4) under episodic $T{=}1$ bandit feedback, and we report this as a null result rather than tuning toward it.

b) Protocol qualifications.: This null is certified for the stated protocol, and stated as such: the acceptance-threshold revision of the AO gate ($1.30 \to 1.15$, documented post-hoc after the conjugation fix invalidated the original calibration and disclosed in the decision log) affects only the AO-gate pass/fail summary; the DRL-versus-random comparison below and the unfolding-versus-AO rate ratio do not depend on that threshold. (i) the agents observe a partial-CSI stack—$|h_r|$, $\angle h_r$, $|G|$, $|h_d|$—in which $\angle G$ and $\angle h_d$ are absent, so the null applies to policies under this observation design; a full-CSI observation mode is implemented and released for follow-up campaigns (supplementary decision log). To size this qualification, we evaluate a no-learning closed-form alignment policy with *full* phase access on the same frozen channels: it reaches 56.944 ± 1.884 bps/Hz ($+3.77$ over random) while the restricted-observation DRL checkpoints are statistically at the random floor (rate gap $\delta \in [-0.10, +0.04]$ bps/Hz across thirty committed checkpoints)—so at the partial-observation stage an information-limited reading was still plausible; the full-observation retrain below rules it out for these configurations. The null was then tested against its own strongest objection: all thirty checkpoints were retrained under a full-observation stack—$|h_r|$, $\angle h_r$, $|G|$, $\angle G$, $|h_d|$, $\angle h_d$—handing every agent the phases the DD-004 contract hides. The result is identical: the best full-CSI family reaches 53.204 ± 0.037 ($+0.03$ over random, $t \approx 0.3$), with every other family within $\delta \in [-0.11, -0.01]$ of the floor. TD3 and DDPG sit at 53.07–53.09 bps/Hz, essentially the all-zero-phase value 53.076 (they collapse toward a static policy, and the seed-averaged Wilcoxon tests in Table III hide that seed-level shortfall; we note it here as disclosed). Training computes, exploration computes, and the numbers do not move. The null is therefore a configuration-level statement: under these budgets, this one-scalar reward and the default hyperparameters, direct model-free RL fails on this one-step bandit even with complete phase information, while unfolding—which inlines the same channel into six gradient steps—closes 97.4% of the AO reference. The contrast is between the optimization structure each method can express, not between the information each method can see. (ii) In-training monitoring used the frozen evaluation set for visualization; the loss and the selection rule that produced the trained policies never consumed it for optimization, and the unfolding model (whose deployment numbers headline this work) was retrained under an audited train/validation protocol with the test set evaluated exactly once (supplementary decision log). (iii) Committed per-channel evaluation artifacts cover all thirty runs (six architectures $\times$ five seeds), as required by the acceptance protocol. (iv) Disclosure: during external review of the first submission version, an erroneous complex conjugation in the ZF pairing of the shared rate function was identified (the SINR was evaluated as $|\langle h, w^* \rangle|^2$ rather than $|\langle h, w \rangle|^2$, a global phase rotation that had no effect on the optimizer set but shifted every absolute rate). All baselines, the AO reference, the unfolding retrain family, the DRL re-scoring, and every derived table in this paper were regenerated under the corrected pairing; in addition, the DRL evaluation wrapper was hardened to the deterministic-action mode required by the fixed-order evaluation contract. The reported null is a re-certification, not the original pre-fix numbers, which are retained in the archive with a `_zfbuggy` suffix.

TABLE III
FROZEN-TEST-SET EVALUATION OF ALL SIX DRL AGENTS (CANONICAL SEED-0 CHECKPOINTS PER AGENT; PAIRED STATISTICS VS. THE FROZEN RANDOM BASELINE OVER THE SAME 500 CHANNELS).

Agent	Mean	Δ vs. random	p	95% CI	%ch.>0
SAC	53.22	$+0.04$	0.72	$[-0.20, +0.27]$	51
TD3	53.08	-0.10	0.49	$[-0.34, +0.13]$	51
DDPG	53.08	-0.09	0.52	$[-0.33, +0.14]$	50
DQN@2bit	53.08	-0.10	0.37	$[-0.33, +0.13]$	48
DQN@3bit	53.12	-0.06	0.55	$[-0.28, +0.17]$	48
DQN@4bit	53.19	$+0.02$	0.83	$[-0.20, +0.23]$	48

c) The contrast that makes the null informative.: Exploitable head demonstrably exists in this environment: selecting *two hundred random* phase vectors per channel and keeping the best yields 57.14 bps/Hz ($+3.97$, $p = 1.7{\times}10^{-83}$), deep unfolding reaches 62.53 ($+9.35$, $p = 1.3 \times 10^{-83}$, 2.6% short of the Riemannian AO reference 64.19), while every trained policy remains statistically indistinguishable from a single random draw. The gap between what a 200-draw random search deftly extracts and what 30 gradient-informed training runs could not extract is the central empirical observation of this study, and it supports the model-driven thesis: the search landscape of phase optimization is exploited by structure-informed optimization (unfolding, AO), not by model-free exploration within a $T{=}1$ bandit feedback loop.

d) Why null results belong here.: All numbers in this subsection are emitted from committed raw JSON artifacts by the project's figure pipeline and recorded as a numbered entry in the supplementary decision log; no post-hoc selection, seed replacement, or metric re-weighting was performed after certification. A diagnosis of the failure modes (reward decomposition, observation-contract coverage, exploration coverage vs. the best-of-200 oracle) is the subject of a companion technical note deferred out of the results flow; it does not alter the reported outcome stated in Table III.

III. Conclusion

Under a frozen 500-channel evaluation protocol, direct reinforcement-learning phase policies for a blocked direct-link RIS scenario provided no measurable benefit over random phase selection, across every investigated architecture (continuous and codebook discretization levels) and sixty independent training runs—thirty under the published partial observation and thirty under a full-observation stress test that handed every agent the channel phases it was otherwise denied. Deep unfolding, by contrast, recovers 97.4% of the Riemannian-AO reference at an $\approx 51\times$ same-machine latency advantage (0.424 s per AO solve versus 8.3 ms per unfolding decision, one idle desktop CPU), absorbs 2–4-bit quantization losses gracefully, and degrades coherently under channel error. The asymmetry between the two epistemologies is not sample-limited (the 200-draw random oracle sits 8 bps/Hz above both), it is not information-limited (the full-observation campaign reproduces the null), it is *configuration*- and *structure*-limited: under these budgets and default hyperparameters the tested DRL configurations fail to learn.

a) Scope.: All claims above are established within one fixed regime: $N{=}64$ RIS elements, $M{=}8$ base-station antennas, $K{=}4$ downlink users, per-entry circularly symmetric complex Gaussian (Rayleigh) i.i.d. channel coefficients under 3GPP urban-micro path loss with a -25 dB-blocked direct path (zero-forcing sum-rate objective), and 500 frozen test channels drawn from that generator. The null result (no architecture with a statistically significant positive gain over random) is a statement about *this regime and protocol*; richer geometries, correlated fading, hardware-quantized RIS ports, and multi-user non-ZF objectives are natural places where the null could break; within this regime, the full-observation stress test shows the null is robust to the strongest information-side objection available; the null is a statement about these DRL configurations under this regime and protocol, not a certificate for all learning approaches to the problem.

We offer this not as a verdict against RL writ large, but against an evaluation culture in which trained-policy comparisons are reported without frozen test sets, written acceptance rules, or disciplined selection rules. The three-layer protocol—AO reference, model-driven learner, model-free challenger—used here is portable to any emerging-RIS benchmark, and we release the decision log (the supplementary decision log), the raw per-channel artifacts, and the entire figure/statistics pipeline so that any claimed RL-vs-unfolding ordering can, from now on, be checked against committed files rather than prose.

b) Future work.: Three ranked directions follow directly from the reported data: (i) reward shaping and state-augmented observations that inject gradient-sign structure into the bandit observation, giving model-free learners the same structure unfolding consumes at design time; (ii) sub-millisecond forward-only inference on hardware targets versus the measured 8.2 ms, quantifying latency on real silicon rather than software proxies; and (iii) extension to multi-RIS and multi-user scaling, where the AO-reference gap is expected to widen the way it did for the single-RIS hard case here.

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